



BEFORE

The institution of slavery was a primary influence on the society and economy of the prewar South.

THE OLD SOUTH



THE AUCTION OF AN ENSLAVED MAN

While the South was not a uniform region, slavery united its people. On this captive labor force rested the cash-crop plantation system. Slaves grew a variety of staples including cotton—and “King Cotton” gave the South **great political power**. But its “slave society” meant more than the racial and economic subjugation of 4 million slaves (see [Organizing for the Fight](#)). It **maintained white privilege** and Southerners argued that the North had lost values of community in the pursuit of materialistic gain.

The Civil War took its horrifying toll on American society, with both the North and the South suffering terrible losses. The total number of military deaths in the war exceeded 620,000—two percent of the entire population in 1860. The military death toll for the Civil War was the same as that for all other American wars from the Revolution through the Korean War combined. A higher